Fetal Growth Restriction Is a Clinical Outcome, Not a Destiny

INTERGROWTH-21st provides international fetal-size standards; severe restriction is clinically meaningful, but birth size is not a proxy for intelligence, worth, or future personality.

ADE: MODERATE-STANDARDS; HIGH-PERCENTILE-NOT-DESTINY | STATUS: DRAFT | DOMAIN: PREGNANCY | REPLICATION: VERIFI

WHAT WE KNOW (Narrowest Supported Conclusion)

Fetal growth reflects genes, placenta, maternal condition, and environment. INTERGROWTH-21st constructed international ultrasound standards from low-risk pregnancies so that size can be interpreted against a common chart. Severe restriction is clinically meaningful. Birth size is not intelligence, worth, or personality. Prenatal differences can attenuate, persist, or change form after birth; persistence must be measured (CH02-C13).

EVIDENCE AND CAUSAL ASSESSMENT

Papageorghiou et al. (2014), INTERGROWTH-21st Fetal Growth Longitudinal Study: 4,321 low-risk pregnancies across eight countries; serial ultrasound from 14 weeks; centiles for head circumference, BPD, OFD, abdominal circumference, femur length. This is a standards paper, not a trial of smallness. Continuity after birth is a longitudinal claim: attenuation, persistence, and transformation are all possible; none can be assumed from size alone.

EFFECT SIZE AND PERSISTENCE

Distinguish percentile difference, functional difference, and impairment. Dating error and constitutional smallness are not placental failure.

BIAS, HETEROGENEITY, AND CONFOUNDING

GI attenuation: n/a (normative anthropometric measurement standard, not an observational exposure).

Low-risk INTERGROWTH sample is prescriptive, not a census of all fetuses; collider/selection if only small babies are followed; postnatal nutrition.

WHAT THIS DOES NOT MEAN (Strict Boundary Conditions)

Does not mean a small newborn is a lesser child, or that catch-up proves the prenatal period was irrelevant.

WHAT ACTION IS REASONABLY JUSTIFIED

Clinical surveillance of true growth restriction is justified. Treating a percentile as a forecast of character is not.

VERIFIED SOURCES & DOI IDENTIFIERS

- Papageorghiou et al. (2014), Lancet (INTERGROWTH-21st)